

Urinary-tract infection

» What, when, and how often?

A stinging sensation when you urinate is usually the first sign of a bacterial infection in your bladder, also known as cystitis. You may experience lower back pain (in your kidney region), and pain in your abdomen.

» What causes it?

Increased estrogen levels in your system can lead to increased levels of the *E. coli* bacteria in your gut, which makes you more prone to urinary-tract infection. This is compounded by the slower transit of urine through your system as a result of pregnancy hormones, and the increased pressure of your uterus on your ureters—the tubes that carry urine from your kidneys.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Urinary-tract infections require treatment with antibiotics. If left untreated, they can lead to a more complicated kidney infection, which can increase the

Cranberries Research has been done into cranberry juice helping to prevent and alleviate the symptoms of urinary-tract infections. The results are inconclusive, but it's worth a try.



amount of fluid in your circulation, putting pressure on your heart. About 2 percent of pregnant women in the US develop a kidney infection. This is also treated with antibiotics. You are at a small increased risk of preterm labor, and your baby may catch the infection during birth.

» What can I do?

Drink plenty of fluids throughout your pregnancy to keep flushing out your system. See your doctor right away if you suspect that you could have a urinary-tract infection.

Inability to urinate

» What, when, and how often?

This sounds like the opposite problem from the one most pregnant women complain about, but it is exactly as it sounds—you feel the need to go to the bathroom, but nothing comes out.

» What causes it?

As the baby grows, your bladder is pushed up inside your abdomen, and once it's out of the way, the baby is free to lie on the urethra—the tube that allows urine to run out of your bladder. If the tube is blocked or squashed, you can't urinate.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

You need to be able to drain urine from your body, otherwise toxins are reabsorbed back into your system, and you are at increased risk of getting a kidney infection.

» What can I do?

See your doctor immediately. Usually, your baby will shift position and naturally free up your urethra, but if that doesn't happen, you may need to have a catheter inserted in order to drain urine from your bladder.

Lower abdominal pressure and "PPGP"

» What, when, and how often?

A dull ache or stabbing pain low down in your pelvic region may cause lower abdominal pressure during your

pregnancy, particularly in the later stages. "PPGP" stands for pregnancy-related pelvic girdle pain. It was formerly known as symphysis pubic dysfunction and affects one in five pregnant women. It can be incredibly painful.

» What causes it?

As your uterus grows during your pregnancy, it presses on the various bones and ligaments of your pelvis. This effect is compounded when the baby grows into the space too. PPGP is caused by hormonal changes that affect the way the pelvic joint functions.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

There is no danger to you or the baby from this kind of

abdominal pressure—it's just a side effect of pregnancy. If, though, the pain is unbearable it could be a sign that something else is wrong. PPGP can continue for three to six months after the birth.

» What can I do?

For both conditions relax in warm bath water. For PPGP keep your legs together when getting out of bed and into bed or in and out of a car. Sleep on your left side with a pillow between your legs (see p.114). Ask your doctor for an elastic tubular bandage or a support belt.

Abdominal pains

» What, when, and how often?

Early on in your pregnancy, it's common to experience some cramping in your abdomen since your uterus prepares itself to provide a safe house for your developing fetus. By the second trimester, abdominal pain may move to the sides of your abdomen. Pain later in your pregnancy is more likely to be the result of indigestion than anything more sinister.

» What causes them?

Implantation and expansion in your uterus are the most common causes of cramping during early pregnancy. Then, when your body starts to loosen up as a result of increased progesterone and relaxin levels, you may feel as though you're getting pains at the sides of your abdomen—these are just signs that your ligaments are softening to allow room in your pelvis for your growing baby. Occasionally, you may have a small internal bleed in your uterus and this can give you abdominal pain.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Early stage abdominal pains are normal, but mention them to your doctor so that you can be checked to ensure all is well. If you have any pain at any time in your pregnancy that is accompanied by bleeding, call your doctor

Hemorrhoids

» What, when, and how often?

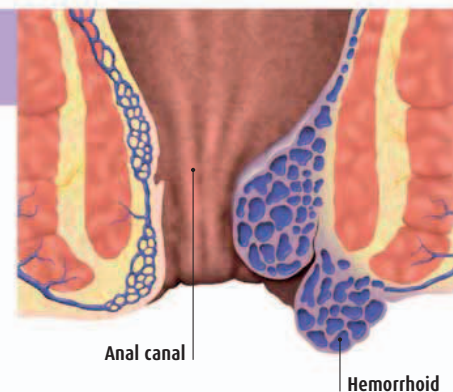
Hemorrhoids are dilated blood vessels around the inside or edge of the anus.

» What causes them?

During pregnancy a woman is more likely to get hemorrhoids because the hormonal softening of the tissues around the anus. Also, the pressure from the baby's head on the blood vessels is another factor. Constipation can cause hemorrhoids to occur.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Having hemorrhoids can be uncomfortable or even painful in more severe cases, but pose no risk to you or your baby.



Anal canal

Hemorrhoid

» What can I do?

Avoid getting constipated or straining when you pass stool. Cold packs and creams can relieve the discomfort. A doctor might be able to reduce a hemorrhoid by pushing it gently back into place.